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Examining how organizational continuities and discontinuities affect the job satisfaction of global contractors

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ABSTRACT

Global offshoring has become a key strategy for international staffing, especially in the software industry. Global software teams engage in boundary spanning activities that may help MNEs achieve international connectivity and cope with external disruptions through their use of virtual work. However, offshoring IT professionals who bridge these boundaries in offshoring MNEs must contend with discontinuities, or perceived disruptions in expected communication flows, which impact their job satisfaction. Drawing on survey data from 193 professional consultants from an IT services offshoring MNE located primarily in Eastern Europe and working for a U.S. client, we test a model grounded in Organizational Discontinuity Theory. We find that potential discontinuities arising from the virtual work environment have no impact on the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals, but that those who experience team-level continuities of identification and shared vision are more satisfied with their jobs. Our findings suggest that virtual work may have become normalized such that it is not problematic in and of itself, and that fostering connectivity in boundary spanning global teams may be beneficial for MNEs. Our findings have important implications for MNEs managing disruptions created by global work arrangements as well as exogenous disruptions.

1. Introduction

Global offshoring in multinational enterprises (MNEs) has become a key strategy for international staffing and talent management, especially in the software industry (Carmel and Agarwal, 2002; Kshetri, 2007; Mithas and Lucas, 2010). The rapid development of the offshore and multi-shore software outsourcing services industry has resulted in the creation of new forms of MNEs that may originate in either industrialized or developing economies (Gannon, 2007). While different outsourcing models exist, they typically involve the use of offshoring IT professionals who perform work either onshore at the client location or offshore in a remote location (Mukherjee et al., 2013). Such workers frequently engage in boundary spanning activities and play an important role in facilitating knowledge sharing and integration between the MNE HQ and its subsidiaries (Meyer et al., 2020) – and in the case of MNE agency firms, with the client organization as well.

Global offshoring arrangements can provide greater connectivity and coordination for MNEs as they allow them to access knowledge and skills around the globe, often at reduced labor costs (Bjørn et al., 2019; Ceci and Prencipe, 2013). However, they pose

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unique challenges for offshoring IT professionals, who must navigate disruptions in virtual work environments that transcend the boundaries of time, space, organization, and culture (Mattarelli et al., 2017; Watson-Manheim et al., 2002). In addition, external disruptions, or exogeneous shocks, such as the COVID-19 global pandemic and geopolitical events, such as the current Russian war in Ukraine, have resulted in location diversification of global employees, which has led to a greater need for boundary spanning to connect dispersed MNE activities (Schotter, 2021). While working virtually may create *discontinuities* (perceived disruptions in the expected flow of communication, Crowston et al., 2015) in the global work environment, it may also help to buffer MNEs from external disruptions by allowing for more choice in the location of work.

Global offshoring arrangements are an important type of virtual work environment in which onshore and offshore workers collaborate and engage in boundary-spanning knowledge sharing (Eisenberg and Mattarelli, 2017; Espinosa et al., 2007; Mattarelli et al., 2017). Working in global virtual teams, offshoring IT professionals act as boundary spanners by working across boundaries of location, distance, and time (Jimenez et al., 2017), as well as across organizational boundaries (Riemer and Vehring, 2012). Thus, they play an important role in providing MNEs with global connectivity; however, the global work context adds complexity due to the need to coordinate work across multiple boundaries (Schotter et al., 2017). The potential discontinuities arising from the global virtual work environment can be disruptive to team communication and coordination (Watson-Manheim et al., 2002).

Global work boundaries are not inherently problematic, however; they may be navigated smoothly if teams develop shared practices and routines to provide continuity such that boundaries are not disruptive. Such bridging factors for overcoming discontinuities, referred to as *continuities* (Watson-Manheim et al., 2002), provide mechanisms that foster a sense of belonging and collective understanding and contribute to the job satisfaction of IT professionals from offshoring MNE firms. Understanding the interplay between discontinuities and continuities may help to explain why the widespread shift to remote or virtual work during COVID-19 has had a mix of positive and negative effects on team collaboration (Fayard et al., 2021; Szelwach and Matthews, 2021; Waizenegger et al., 2020).

We propose that offshoring IT professionals with a strong sense of team identification and shared vision are better able to cope with disruptions in their work through more meaningful social interactions and connections, and that they experience greater job satisfaction as a result. Guided by Organizational Discontinuity Theory (ODT), we draw on data from a field study of a global outsourcing MNE founded in the United States and headquartered in Minsk, Belarus with subsidiaries in other parts of Eastern Europe.

Recent research applying ODT to virtual work environments has focused on internal virtual organizations (Lauring et al., 2022), even those operating within the same time zone (Asiatiani & Penttinen, 2019). Our study helps to extend ODT by empirically testing it in a global outsourcing context, which involves greater complexity by crossing geographical, temporal, cultural, and organizational boundaries. Survey data from 193 offshoring IT professionals reveal that discontinuities of geographical dispersion, cultural diversity, electronic dependence, and dynamic structure (Gibson and Gibbs, 2006) have no association with job satisfaction. On the other hand, team-level continuities of team identification and shared vision are linked to greater job satisfaction. Our findings suggest that virtual work environments may have become normalized such that they are no longer perceived as disruptive, and that developing a sense of belonging and shared vision at the team level helps offshoring IT professionals feel more connected and increases their job satisfaction. These findings may have wider implications for MNE connectivity in the post-COVID era, given the prevalence of remote work and job mobility.

2. Literature review

Global offshoring is an important MNE strategy that involves outsourcing "R&D and knowledge-intensive work to captive centres, third-party service providers, or alliance partners located in emerging countries" (Mattarelli and Tagliaventi, 2015, p. 585). Global virtual teams are often used as a boundary spanning mechanism to coordinate work between offshore and onsite locations (Mattarelli and Gupta, 2009), either between MNE headquarters and subsidiaries or with external vendor firms (e.g., Oshri et al., 2007). While the traditional model of global offshoring consisted of MNEs in highly industrialized countries outsourcing R&D and knowledge-intensive work to lower-cost centers in developing countries such as India or China, these core-periphery dynamics are being reversed and complicated by trends such as the rise of emerging market multinational enterprises (EMNEs) with subsidiaries in developed countries (e.g., Patel et al., 2021) and the growth and mobility of highly skilled immigrant professionals, or "new Argonauts" (Saxenian, 2006). New types of MNEs such as IS offshore MNEs have arisen to service the global software market. These service firms are located in offshore locations with lower labor costs to win business in more developed markets (Gannon, 2007). These trends both increase and complicate the nature of international connectivity in MNEs. Global work in MNEs is associated with a number of challenges stemming from multiple inter- and intra-organizational boundaries that separate workers due to differences in the location-specific contexts in which they are embedded (Goerzen, 2018; Jimenez et al., 2017). Global organizations are inherently complex and are becoming more so as their operational and contextual diversity increases (Schotter et al., 2017) due to globalization and technological advances (Doz and Wilson, 2012).

Global offshoring takes place through virtual work, in which employees work from dispersed locations using electronic communication technology (Raghuram et al., 2019) to span boundaries of time and space. While virtual work has been commonplace for at least two decades, the COVID-19 global pandemic has resulted in an even more widespread shift to remote or virtual work, with mixed implications for MNEs in terms of its effects on work structure and international connectivity more broadly. On one hand, working virtually has long been perceived as liberating for both individual workers and firms due to the removal of constraints on the physical environment that make work independent of location and office hours (e.g., Nilles, 1975). The increased ability for employees to relocate may also help MNEs to weather external disruptions related to geopolitical events or other environmental factors (Schotter, 2021). On the other hand, working remotely is likely to lead to decreased job satisfaction by weakening workers' sense of connection to their workplace and creating challenges to their mental health and well-being (Krug et al., 2021). Further, virtual workers often experience professional and social isolation (Asatiani and Penttinen, 2019). In order to achieve connectivity benefits for MNEs, it is thus imperative to understand how to make global work arrangements more satisfying for virtual workers.

2.1. *Theoretical model of organizational discontinuities and continuities*

Virtuality and virtual work are associated with tasks and responsibilities that cross boundaries of geography, culture, work organization, work practices, and technology (Asatiani and Penttinen, 2019). According to Organizational Discontinuity Theory (ODT), such boundaries are likely to lead to discontinuities, which are defined as "gaps or a lack of coherence in aspects of work, such as work setting, task, and relations with other workers or managers" (Watson-Manheim et al., 2002, p. 193). For instance, Asatiani and Penttinen (2019) pointed out that discontinuities of professional and social isolation often arise as virtual workers traverse boundaries of time and space. A key assumption of ODT is that discontinuities are not just static structural features but apply to both work practices in the virtual environment as well as different perceptions about them. In this sense they differ from boundaries – which may be latent or unperceived – by involving a recognized disruption of some sort. Discontinuities are inherently communicative, in that they are "created at a boundary when an individual perceives a change in information and communication flows that requires conscious effort and attention to handle" (Watson-Manheim et al., 2012, p. 36). Thus, a discontinuity is a perceived disruption in the flow of communication. It requires more attention and effort to manage, as individuals need to make sense of the disruption and address the problem (Crowston et al., 2015). See Table 1 for a broad list of discontinuities that may exist in virtual work environments.

Discontinuities are not necessarily a given, though. In other words, virtuality boundaries are not necessarily a problem and they do not pose the same problems for all workers and teams, but it depends on the contextual factors that shape perceptions of boundaries as disruptive. This suggests that virtual work boundaries have varying effects on workers in different contexts (Sivunen et al., 2016). Discontinuities are thus based on individual perceptions, and are highly dependent on time and context. Physical or structural boundaries, such as time zones, may or may not become disruptive, depending on how specific teams manage these boundaries (Asatiani and Penttinen, 2019). For example, teams that work across time zones may experience difficulties in scheduling meetings, especially if they forget to specify the time zone of the meeting time and team members interpret it differently (discontinuity).

More importantly, they may be mitigated through the development of continuities, which are structures or practices that create shared understandings about work (Watson-Manheim et al., 2012). It is often the case that discontinuities necessitate the emergence of continuities, or new practices and expectations that minimize the amount of attention and effort required to manage problematic boundaries (i.e., discontinuities). For instance, a time-zone discontinuity among team members can be changed into a continuity by specifying local times and time zones for all members when scheduling meetings (Crowston et al., 2015) or adopting a "follow the sun" model (Carmel et al., 2010) in which work is handed off to a member in the next time-zone in order to maximize work around the clock. Cultural diversity can also be converted into a continuity by encouraging constructive dialogue, debate, and creative problem-solving (Lauring et al., 2022). Continuities have been identified at both the individual level and the team level. For instance, Lauring et al. (2022) argue that interaction between continuities at different levels should be taken into account, and they find that individual level continuities of trust in peers and time zone adjustment are both associated with job role clarity and job performance, and that team-level openness to diversity moderates these relationships.

We apply ODT to global offshoring as a form of virtual work that involves collaboration on tasks across geographical, temporal, organizational, and cultural boundaries. Offshoring IT professionals navigate discontinuous organizational affiliations (e.g., client versus outsourcing organization). They also experience discontinuities in their work group memberships, as they often work with colleagues of different nationalities and diverse functional backgrounds. They further experience physical and temporal discontinuity as their work spans multiple geographical locations and time zones. This may make it difficult for them to develop and maintain good working relationships in a virtual environment, negatively impacting their job satisfaction. We draw on ODT (Lauring et al., 2022; Watson-Manheim et al., 2012) to develop a theoretical model to understand how discontinuities in the global work environment interact with continuities to influence the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals. We propose that offshoring IT professionals are likely to experience discontinuities along four key features of virtuality identified by Gibson and Gibbs (2006): geographical dispersion, cultural diversity, electronic dependence, and dynamic structure. We utilize this typology for our conceptual model rather

Table 1
Virtual work discontinuities[a].

Virtual work boundaries	Discontinuities
Geography	Physical distance – working remotely and/or collaborating with people in different locations – leads to professional and social isolation, knowledge sharing challenges
Time	Time zone differences create confusion over meeting times, lack of synchronous interaction and overlap in work day
Culture	Differences in national and professional or functional culture lead to conflict, misunderstandings, lack of trust, ingroup/outgroup divisions, different mental schema
Work practices	Differences in work practices due to different understandings of how work should be done, dynamic structure and changing members
Organization	MNE and outsourcing organizations create different identities (temporary vs. permanent workers) and organizational affiliations as well as status differences
Technology	Different norms and practices around technology use, differences in infrastructure, level of access, and support

[a] Based on Chudoba et al. (2005).

than the one identified by Chudoba et al. (2005) in Table 1, because it contains the additional dimension of dynamic structure – which is highly relevant in global offshoring MNEs that use project-based, contract work.

In the next section, we develop a theoretical rationale for these four features as salient discontinuities and their relationships with job satisfaction. We further develop two organizational continuities at the team level – team identification and shared vision – that may have positive relationships with job satisfaction. Fig. 1 outlines our conceptual model.

2.2. *Organizational discontinuities and job satisfaction*

Job satisfaction is critical for the success of an organization. Organizations with higher job satisfaction rates among their employees are likely to have higher performance, in contrast to those with lower job satisfaction (Ostroff, 1992). Multiple factors influence offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction, which is defined as "...a pleasurable or positive emotional state resulting from the appraisal of one's job or job experiences" (Locke, 1976, p. 1304). It develops through cognitive and affective reactions that individuals experience on the job, combining what an employee feels with what they think about the job (Rayton and Yalabik, 2014).

Organizational scholars have long contended that job satisfaction is derived from social interaction and feelings of connection with one's co-workers. The human relations school of management (Maslow, 1954; Mayo, 1949) recognized that employees have social needs for interaction and meaningful relationships and that fulfilling these needs provides them with motivation and satisfaction in their work. Traditional theories of motivation, such as those in the human relations school as well as the Job Characteristics Model (Hackman and Oldham, 1980), tend to assume that employee needs are fulfilled through face-to-face interactions. As Gibson et al. (2011) argue, virtual work environments change the frequency and quality of social interactions, which may have implications for employee satisfaction.

Prior research has produced mixed findings on the relationship between virtual or remote work and job satisfaction, as mentioned above. Some literature suggests that virtuality is likely to negatively impact the job satisfaction of virtual workers as it weakens interpersonal relationships and interaction, which provide important sources of job satisfaction (Fay and Kline, 2011; Fonner and Roloff, 2010). A review of virtual teams research found that satisfaction depends on contingency factors, such as task type and member composition, but that in general, members of virtual teams report lower satisfaction than members of face-to-face teams (Martins et al., 2004). We draw on ODT to identify specific discontinuities and continuities that are likely to influence the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals, in order to help reconcile the mixed findings in previous literature. We start by predicting that organizational discontinuities, which arise due to geographical dispersion, cultural diversity, lack of face-to-face dependence, and dynamic structure, are likely to be associated with lower job satisfaction for IT professionals. We then turn to identify two continuities (sense of team identification and shared vision) that may increase their job satisfaction.

2.2.1. *Geographical dispersion and job satisfaction*

First, we predict that geographical dispersion is likely to negatively impact job satisfaction. Research has documented challenges facing geographically distributed workers in collaborating across locations and time zones (O'Leary and Cummings, 2007; Olson and Olson, 2000). Research has found that workers at remote locations are often inadvertently left out of decision making as they are "out

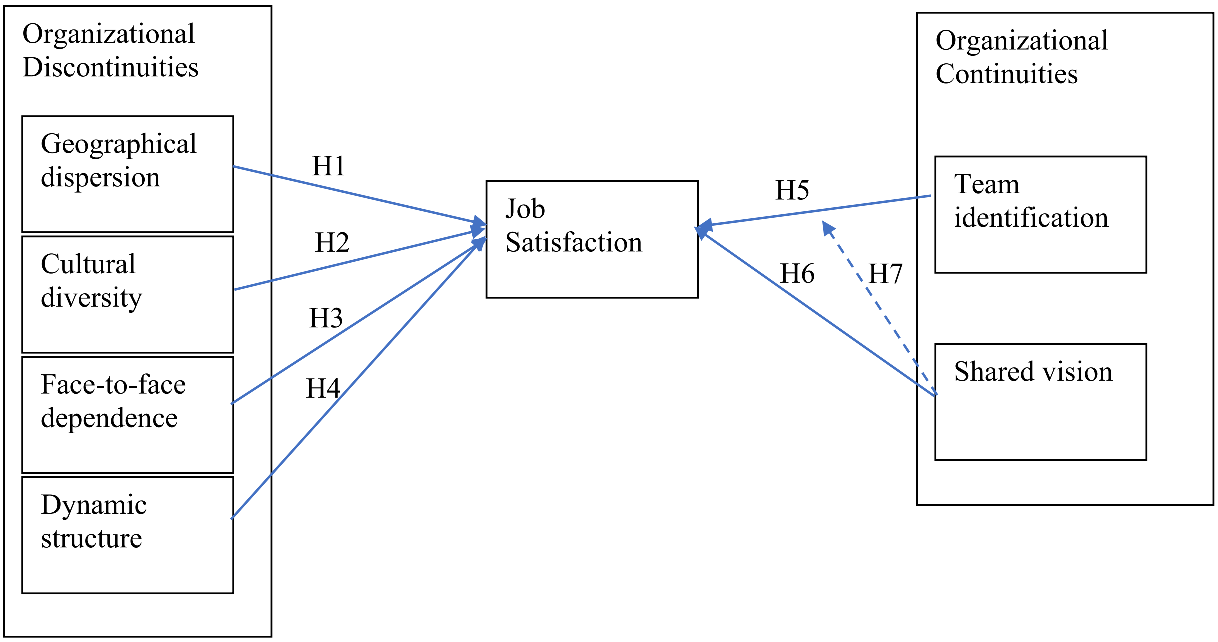

Fig. 1. Conceptual model.

of sight, out of mind" (Grinter et al., 1999). In addition, distributed workers face challenges sharing knowledge due to lack of common ground and shared context (Olson and Olson, 2000; Sole and Edmondson, 2002) that may harm interpersonal relationships as distributed team members make faulty attributions about one another (Cramton et al., 2007). Global team members have also been found to discursively construct subgroups based geographical locations that differ in status (Gibbs et al., 2021). Mattarelli and Gupta (2009) found that onsite-offshore teams, in particular, experience status differences across subgroups that privilege the onsite location and impact knowledge sharing processes. An important source of dissatisfaction among offshore professionals is that they are often assigned work that is less challenging and rewarding than their Western counterparts (Mattarelli and Tagliaventi, 2015; Metiu, 2006). Working across geographical locations reduces the frequency of communication and weakens relational ties (Lauring et al., 2022), which are an important source of motivation and satisfaction. This is likely to create discontinuities related to reduced intimacy and social closeness, and thus be detrimental to job satisfaction (Gibson et al., 2011). Thus, we hypothesize that:

H1. Geographical dispersion will be negatively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

2.2.2. Cultural diversity and job satisfaction

Global work environments are also highly diverse, as employees from different nationalities and cultural backgrounds, as well as with different functional expertise, work together (Gibbs, 2009a). By definition, global outsourcing involves hiring contractual workers from different countries to access talent and expertise that is lacking at the client site, and thus such work arrangements are likely to be both culturally and functionally diverse. We propose that the extent to which offshoring IT professionals experience work group membership discontinuity (in terms of cultural and functional diversity) is likely to impact their job satisfaction. Working with co-workers from diverse cultural or functional backgrounds is likely to require more effort in terms of negotiating different norms, expectations, communication styles, and cultural differences often create misunderstandings and conflicts among team members (Gibson and Gibbs, 2006).

Offshoring IT professionals often work in global virtual teams whose members come from diverse cultural backgrounds and who negotiate multiple identities, resulting in divisive subgroups that create 'us versus them' dynamics within the team (Eisenberg and Mattarelli, 2017). IT professionals in offshoring arrangements are likely to face discrimination due to their national origins based on negative associations with offshore outsourcing of white-collar jobs among workers in the U.S. and other Western countries (Das et al., 2008). Workers from offshore locations are also likely to be treated as lower status by those in the headquarters location (Metiu, 2006). This negative treatment is likely to lower their job satisfaction. In addition, differences in functional expertise are likely to impede social interactions among team members who speak specialized occupational languages and occupy different "thought worlds" (Kim, 2018) in part due to lower levels of shared experience and increased task related disagreements (Majchrzak et al., 2011). This suggests that offshoring IT professionals who work in culturally diverse teams (in terms of different nationalities and job functions) may experience discontinuities that lead to lower job satisfaction.

H2. Cultural diversity will be negatively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

2.2.3. (Lack of) face-to-face dependence and job satisfaction

Gibson and Gibbs (2006) examined electronic dependence as one of their virtuality features and found that it was negatively associated with innovation. A review of virtual teams research found that satisfaction depends on contingency factors, such as task type and member composition, but that in general, members of virtual teams report lower satisfaction than members of face-to-face teams (Martins et al., 2004). The authors provide the rationale that computer-mediated communication (e.g., electronic chat; Graetz et al., 1998) requires more cognitive effort and may be more frustrating. Gilson et al. (2015) do acknowledge that most of the virtual teams research has studied older technologies, such as email, chat, and discussion boards, rather than newer technologies, such as enterprise social media or meeting tools. Assuming that electronic communication has become the norm for teams, we choose instead to focus on face-to-face dependence, as an indicator of the degree to which team members use and rely on face-to-face interaction. Indeed, research has found that face-to-face use at certain points in a team's life cycle can be beneficial (Erhardt et al., 2016; Michinov and Michinov, 2007). In this sense, a low degree of face-to-face dependence would indicate higher virtuality or discontinuity. We propose that lack of face-to-face dependence may lead to discontinuities that are negatively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

H3. Lack of face-to-face dependence will be negatively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

2.2.4. Dynamic structure and job satisfaction

Outsourcing is usually structurally dynamic and is associated with temporal discontinuities, defined as dynamic structure (Gibson and Gibbs, 2006). Dynamic structure includes short-term project arrangements and work that is characterized by frequent change in participants as well as their roles and relationships (Gibson and Gibbs, 2006). Dynamic structure may hinder team members' experiences due to a range of factors, such as diminished knowledge sharing, reduced socialization, and increased uncertainty and risk (Weber and Kim, 2015). Offshoring IT professionals who are contracted by MNE consultancy firms to work in client firms are typically working as temporary workers in short-term, project teams. This dynamic structure is likely to diminish contractors' attachments to their organization, and they are likely to feel disenfranchised as non-permanent workers who are not "full-fledged members" of the client organization (George and Chattopadhyay, 2005). Contract employees are often stigmatized and treated as lower status by both managers and co-workers (Boyce et al., 2007) and feel treated like second-class citizens compared to standard client employees, due to their lower job security and expendability (Boswell et al., 2012). Even those who work at MNE subsidiaries through internal captive center models are likely to experience equity concerns when moving onshore to the client site and finding that they are paid less, deprived of benefits such as training, and excluded from team meetings, which has been shown to lead to diminished morale, low job satisfaction, and attrition as foreign assignees resigned from assignments early or left the company in search of jobs with better career growth (Gibbs, 2009b). Thus, we predict that a dynamic structure is likely to create discontinuities that will negatively influence offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction. This leads to our fourth hypothesis.

H4. Dynamic structure will be negatively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

2.3. Organizational continuities and job satisfaction

While offshoring IT professionals may face identity challenges due to their status as temporary members in the client organization, we propose that organizational continuities, such as a sense of team identification and shared vision, may serve as structural anchors that provide a sense of belonging and increase satisfaction with their work assignments. Continuities are structures that provide equivalent or mutual expectations among work group members, and are positioned as factors that can help overcome discontinuities (Watson-Manheim et al., 2012). Examples of continuities are governance mechanisms, practices such as regular meetings, or shared cultural beliefs and values. Continuities are important for successful virtual work as they create shared expectations and understandings around work practices. We propose two continuities at the team level that are likely to help overcome the geographical, functional and cultural, technological, and temporal discontinuities in global offshoring contexts: team identification and shared vision. In this section, we argue that these continuities are positively associated with job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals. When such structures are in place, offshoring IT professionals will feel more safe and secure in their work arrangements and this may encourage them to engage in more social interaction with their virtual colleagues, providing them with greater job satisfaction.

2.3.1. Team identification

Identification is an important continuity to facilitate greater job satisfaction. It is associated with a sense of oneness or belonging to a social group (Ashforth and Mael, 1989), and team identification refers to members' perceptions of oneness with the team and is especially relevant in global work settings (Gibson et al., 2019). Team identification can help offshoring IT professionals face challenges to their organizational identification, which represents a oneness with the organization where the individual incorporates it into their self-concept and acts in its best interests (Ashforth et al., 2008). Through identification, individuals achieve a sense of social connectedness with others, facilitating communication, understanding, and a common purpose (Gossett, 2002).

Identification has been argued to be especially important for connecting virtual employees to their organization (Wiesenfeld et al., 1999). However, in global offshoring contexts identification is more precarious, and offshoring IT professionals are likely to face identity challenges due to their temporary status as well as the need to negotiate multiple identities. As temporary contractors, they face dual allegiances or sources of commitment between the employing and client organizations (Boswell et al., 2012; Coyle-Shapiro et al., 2006; Liden et al., 2003). Further, contractors involved in global work are likely to face additional identity targets, such as nationality, functional background, organizational unit, and location. These multiple identities are likely to be in tension, as for instance cultural characteristics (national identity) interplay with professional choices (professional identity) (D'Mello, 2005; Gibbs, 2009a) or with organizational identity (Mattarelli et al., 2017). Professional identities may also vary across sites (Mattarelli and Tagliaventi, 2010) and lead to organizational tensions (Gotsi et al., 2010). Further, being perceived as an out-group member leads to bias and negative perceptions that impede collaboration, particularly in the context of global teams in MNEs (Vahtera et al., 2017).

While offshoring IT professionals are thus likely to face challenges to their organizational identification, as their status hinders social exchange relationships between the employee and organization, they may instead seek out belonging from their work group through day-to-day work experiences and social interactions with their co-workers (Vough, 2012). Sivunen (2006) found that team identification, in particular, was important in virtual teams. However, she found that the virtual team environment, associated with team members who frequently have different cultural backgrounds, makes it more challenging for a global team leader to foster team identification. In a study of expatriates, role benefits received by workers increased their sense of connection and were associated with more reasons to stay in their jobs, increasing their job satisfaction (Au and Fukuda, 2002). A lack of perceived copresence in distributed settings may reduce virtual workers' job satisfaction, but having a strong sense of identification with their outsourcing organization may help create common ground (Gibson et al., 2011) and a sense of psychological closeness (Wilson et al., 2008) and thus have a positive effect on job satisfaction.

The COVID-19 pandemic has also compromised social identity continuity in the workplace. Krug et al. (2021) studied remote work during COVID-19 and found that employees who perceived greater social identity continuity (on-going membership in a particular organizational unit) were more satisfied with their work and felt less lonely, and they suggest that to foster health and well-being during times of disruption, organizations should put into place practices that help employees to feel a sense of "we-ness" at work with other employees. This highlights the benefits of team identification for job satisfaction, especially during disruptions such as a global pandemic such as lockdowns that prevent employees from connecting with their teams and participating in team meetings or social gatherings in person.

H5. Team identification will be positively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

2.3.2. Shared vision

Having a shared vision can engage and empower workers (Wong et al., 2009), facilitating their connection. Shared vision has been conceptualized as the collective understanding by team or organizational members about a common goal that guides decision-making and behaviors (Colakoglu, 2012; Shoemaker, 1999). Employees involved in discussions of the future are able to fit their roles into a greater context wherein they are able to perceive their value as it relates to the success of the organization (Shoemaker, 1999). Previous research has shown having a shared vision can provide a variety of organizational benefits, including increased trust and information sharing between groups (Tsai and Ghoshal, 1998), organizational citizenship behaviors (Wong et al., 2009), and job satisfaction (Shoemaker, 1999). Shoemaker found that employees who indicated a shared vision felt more secure in their jobs, perceived their work as more meaningful, and considered their work to provide value to the overall functioning of the organization. Shared vision is critical for globally distributed work contexts as it provides a mechanism for integrating diverse and distributed teams (Colakoglu, 2012). Colakoglu found that in MNEs, having a shared vision led to more successful integration of a subsidiary company into a host country by facilitating information sharing and global organizational learning. Similarly, a shared vision may help to integrate offshoring IT professionals into their client teams despite their embeddedness in diverse geographical, cultural, temporal, and organizational contexts (Gluesing and Gibson, 2004). Having a sense of common goals and purpose is thus likely to help to overcome misunderstanding or conflict arising from national diversity (Gibson and Gibbs, 2006) and give offshoring IT professionals a greater sense of job satisfaction as they perceive their work as more meaningful and valuable (Shoemaker, 1999). Indeed, virtual workers with shared goals and high team learning behaviors have been found to achieve high levels of satisfaction (Ortega et al., 2010). This leads to our next hypothesis.

H6. Shared vision will be positively associated with offshoring IT professionals' job satisfaction.

We also predict that team identification and shared vision will interact, such that offshoring IT professionals who are high in both will have the highest job satisfaction. Shared vision is likely to moderate team identification, as when employees internalize role values and goals, they start to feel a greater sense of job satisfaction, especially when there is a lack of identification with the organization or team (Shoemaker, 1999). This leads to our final hypothesis.

H7. Shared vision will moderate team identification to produce higher job satisfaction among offshoring IT professionals.

3. Methods

3.1. Research context and sample

The study was conducted in an IS offshore MNE supplying software engineering and digital transformation IT services to clients in a variety of countries. The MNE was founded as a global partnership between two locations – one in the United States and one in Belarus. While the founder was located in the United States, the company's major operations were in Eastern Europe, with a regional headquarters in Minsk, Belarus. The MNE's location strategy was selected in an effort to open a pipeline to access the immense software talent pool in Central and Eastern Europe to service the global business community. As the company grew over several decades, it acquired companies across the world, increasing its presence to over 60,000 employees in over 50 countries. It is now listed on the New York Stock Exchange and is a Forbes Global 2000 company. It also ranks among the top companies on the Fortune 1000 list of Information Technology Services companies. Our study examined one division based in Minsk, Belarus with subsidiaries in other parts of Belarus, Ukraine, and Russia that provided software services to a U.S.-based client, which was a multinational media firm. The IS offshoring MNE employed IT professionals as consultants in offshore locations with a small percentage of representatives working

Table 2
Sample characteristics ($N = 193$).

Variables	Values, Mean ± SD OR n (%)
Age, mean ± SD (min-max)	28.72 ± 5.73 (20–56)
Sex, n (%)	
Male	138 (71.5)
Female	35 (18.1)
Education, n (%)	
High school or less	1 (0.5)
Some college	3 (1.6)
Bachelors (4 years college)	27 (14.0)
Other masters (5 years college)	134 (69.4)
MBA (6 years college)	3 (1.6)
Doctorate or 7+ years college	4 (2.1)
Other	2 (1.0)
Position, n (%)	
Support staff associate	2 (1.0)
Technical specialist	129 (66.8)
Professional associate	20 (10.4)
Supervisor	6 (3.1)
Middle manager	15 (7.8)
Location, n (%)	
Minsk HQ	134 (69.4)
Subsidiary (Belarus, Ukraine, Russia)	43 (22.3)
Client site in U.S.	16 (8.3)

onsite at the client's location in the United States to coordinate work with the client project teams. The employees who participated in our study were various types of software engineers and project managers who were primarily involved in short-term to medium-term length software development projects. We worked with a high-level manager in the US to recruit IT professionals who were located both offshore and onsite. This manager also provided us with individual and team level characteristics to allow us to estimate the response rate.

A total of 233 individuals from 32 teams participated in our survey. Participants were from 12 different locations across 4 countries: Belarus (76 %), Russia (9 %), Ukraine (7.7 %), and the U.S. (7.3 %), which was a good representation of the overall distribution of contractors. The overall response rate was 65 %. To address the issue of missing data, we removed a few teams that either had less than 2 members respond or most of whose members were missing all their data. For teams with more than 2 respondents, we also removed individuals with missing responses on all of our key variables. This gave us a final sample size of 193 (see Table 2 for detailed demographic characteristics of our participants).

To examine to what extent our dependent and independent variables reflect shared, team-level constructs, we computed the intraclass correlations ICC(1) and ICC(2) (Bliese, 2000; Bryk and Raudenbush, 1982) and the average r_{WG} (James et al., 1984) across teams. ICC(1) indicates the amount of variance that group membership can explain. Following suggestions from Bliese (2000), we calculated ICC(1) using the ratio of between-group mean square (MSB) variance to total variance. We also conducted a one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) with team membership as factor to see whether team membership explained a significant amount of the total variance. In addition, we also reported ICC(2), which shows the reliability of the team-level scores. ICC(2) is commonly interpreted as a reliability coefficient, with values of 0.70 or higher being considered satisfactory. Finally, r_{wg} represents within-team agreement, with values between 0.51 and 0.70 indicating moderate agreement and between 0.71 and 0.90 strong agreement (LeBreton and Senter, 2008). Following suggestions from previous Biemann et al. (2012), we reported $r_{WG\cdot uniform}$ as a value for upper bound and $r_{WG\cdot measure\text{-}specific}$ as a value for lower bound.

Results in Table 3 and Table 4 suggested that we should conduct our analysis at the individual level. Specifically, the ICC (1) values were negative for all of our variables, indicating that the within-group variances was smaller than the between-group variances. For lack of face-to-face dependence, ICC (1) = −0.03, F = 0.78, p = .77; for team identification, ICC (1) = −0.03, F = 0.82, p = .73; for job satisfaction, ICC (1) = −0.03, F = 0.77, p = .78. The r_{WG} results also showed inadequate internal team agreement for face-to-face dependence (mean $r_{WG\cdot uniform}$ = 0.63, mean $r_{WG\cdot measure\text{-}specific}$ = 0.54), and geographic dispersion (mean $r_{WG\cdot uniform}$ = 0.39, mean $r_{WG\cdot measure\text{-}specific}$ = 0.23). Team identification, shared vision, and job satisfaction showed moderate within-team agreement (mean $r_{WG\cdot uniform}$: between 0.70 and 0.78, mean $r_{WG\cdot measure\text{-}specific}$: between 0.43 and 0.53). The results for ICC(1), ICC(2), and r_{WG} on other variables provide evidence for conducting the analysis at the individual level.

In addition, the null model for mixed models showed variation across different teams was insignificant for a multilevel model (Wald Z = 0.04, p = .97). Following Hayes's (2006) recommendation, we also manually computed the likelihood ratio test. In the model with the random intercept, −2LL = 452.808. In models without the random intercept, −2LL = 452.810. For $\chi 2(1) = 0.002$, the p value (p = .96) was not significant with one degree of freedom and thus failed to reject the null hypothesis that the variance of the random intercept component (team) was zero. This provides further justification that multilevel modeling was not necessary and that it was statistically appropriate to test our hypotheses at the individual level (Hayes, 2006).

3.2. Measures

3.2.1. Organizational discontinuities

These were evaluated using the four measures of virtuality from Gibson and Gibbs (2006), with a few alterations. *Geographical dispersion* was measured using 4 items (α = 0.83) focused on team members' dispersion across multiple geographical areas and worksites as well as the necessity of frequent business travel. *Dynamic structure* was evaluated using a 3-item measure (α = 0.73) focused on frequency of team member changes, difficulty knowing who is on the team, and consistency in the team's operating structure. Whereas Gibson and Gibbs measured national diversity specifically, we adopted a broader measure of *cultural diversity* using two items (α = 0.85) focused on team members' work with others who speak different native languages or dialects and collaboration with people from different cultural backgrounds (Chudoba et al., 2005). Finally, instead of electronic dependence – which is a rather dated measure that assumes that technology use is the exception rather than the rule – we opted to measure the degree of dependence on face-to-face, assuming that electronic communication is the norm for most virtual teams. *Face-to-face dependence* was measured using two items (α = 0.77) that asked participants to evaluate both their use and the importance of face-to-face interactions. It was

Table 3
Intraclass correlations on independent and dependent variables.

Variable	ICC(1)	ICC(2)	F[a]	(df1, df2)
Face-to-face	−0.03	−0.28	0.78	(27,184)
Cultural diversity	−0.04	−0.37	0.73	(27,169)
Geographic dispersion	−0.02	−0.17	0.86	(27,168)
Team identification	−0.03	−0.23	0.82	(27,178)
Shared vision	−0.04	−0.34	0.74	(27,181)

[a] The *F ratio* is obtained from a one-way analysis of variance with team membership as factor and indicates the significance of the proportion of variance that is explained by team membership (cf. ICC1).

Table 4
Within-group agreement statistics.

Measure	$r_{WG \cdot uniform}$	$r_{WG \cdot measure\text{-}specific}$		
	Mean	Shape	σ_E^2	Mean
Face-to-face	0.63	Moderate skew	0.90	0.54
Cultural diversity	0.57	Moderate skew	0.90	0.28
Geographic dispersion	0.39	Slight skew	1.34	0.23
Team identification	0.78	Moderate skew	0.90	0.53
Shared vision	0.70	Moderate skew	0.90	0.43

Shape = the shape of an alternative null distribution; σ_E^2 = variance of an alternative null distribution. Variance estimations for measure-specific null distributions (i.e., slight skew, normal, and moderate skew) were taken from LeBreton and Senter (2008, p. 832).

reverse coded to measure lack of face-to-face dependence (as a discontinuity) in the model. All four virtuality features were measured on a 5-point Likert scale.

3.2.2. *Organizational continuities*

These were measured through two team-level variables: team identification and shared vision. *Team identification* was measured by adapting the commonly used organizational identification scale created by Mael and Ashforth (1992), using a 6-item measure (α = 0.85). The items were measured using a 5-point Likert scale and asked about a team member's interest in what others think about their team, whether they feel that their team's successes were their successes, and how they felt when their team was criticized. *Shared vision* was measured using a 3-item measure (α = 0.82) by asking team members to evaluate the extent to which team members were clear on their shared team goals (Edmondson, 1999).

3.2.3. *Job satisfaction*

The dependent variable was measured using an earlier established 4-item scale (α = 0.88), that was used by earlier research (Janz and Prasarnphanich, 2003). The items asked about one's general level of satisfaction, thoughts of quitting one's job, and satisfaction with the kind of work a team member was tasked with doing.

3.2.4. *Controls*

We controlled for *team tenure*, represented by the average time team members were on their team, because earlier research suggests that it can influence team processes and outcomes, including distributed teams (Hackman, 2002; Eisenberg et al., 2019). We also controlled for *location,* which represented whether team members were located at the outsourcing organization's headquarters (in Minsk, Belarus) or not. Literature on global work has documented differences in the experiences of workers at headquarters versus remote locations (Levina and Vaast, 2008; Metiu, 2006), which we believe may also influence their job satisfaction, identification and shared vision.

4. Results

4.1. *Descriptive statistics*

Tables 5 displays the means, standard deviations, scale reliabilities, and zero-order correlations for the study variables. In terms of the virtuality characteristics, geographical dispersion shows significant positive relationships with both cultural diversity ($r = 0.26$, $p < .01$) and dynamic structure ($r = 0.25$, $p < .01$), but no association with face-to-face dependence ($r = -0.12$, ns). Dynamic structure also shows a positive association with team tenure ($r = 0.18$, $p < .05$). Team identification shows positive relationships with face-to-face dependence ($r = 0.20$, $p < .01$) and cultural diversity ($r = 0.17$, $p < .05$), but a negative relationship with dynamic structure ($r =$

Table 5
Mean, standard deviation, and correlation matrix for continuous variables[a].

Variables	*N*	*M*	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Team Tenure	192	3.84	1.35	–							
2. Face-to-Face Dependence	185	3.96	1.10	−0.01	–						
3. Cultural Diversity	170	3.84	1.02	0.10	0.02	(0.85)					
4. Dynamic Structure	171	2.17	0.86	0.18*	−0.09	0.00	(0.73)				
5. Geographic Dispersion	169	3.20	1.13	−0.02	−0.12	0.26**	0.25**	(0.83)			
6. Team Identification (TI)	179	4.06	0.76	0.01	0.20**	0.17*	−0.17*	−0.07	(0.85)		
7. Shared Vision (SV)	182	3.95	0.77	0.02	0.11	0.15	−0.17*	0.03	0.40**	(0.82)	
8. Job Satisfaction	172	3.93	0.78	0.06	0.11	0.22**	−0.09	−0.07	0.53**	0.58**	(0.88)

Note. Cronbach's alphas are shown in the diagonal.
* p < .05.
** p < .01.
[a] Location is not included here since it is a categorical variable – (HQ / non-HQ).

−0.17, $p < .05$). Shared vision also has a negative association with dynamic structure ($r = -0.17$, $p < .05$), but a positive relationship with team identification ($r = 0.40$, $p < .01$). Finally, job satisfaction is positively related to cultural diversity ($r = 0.22$, $p < .01$), team identification ($r = 0.53$, $p < .01$), and shared vision ($r = 0.58$, $p < .01$).

4.2. Hypothesis testing

We tested H1-H6 using hierarchical regression analysis. To test H1-H4, we regressed job satisfaction on the controls (team tenure and location) in Model 1 and then added the four organizational discontinuities (geographical dispersion, face-to-face dependence, cultural diversity, and dynamic structure) in Model 2. The overall regression equation with only controls was not significant, $F(2, 154) = 2.32$, *ns*, and the addition of the four discontinuities did not add a significant amount of explained variance ($\Delta R^2 = 0.04$, *ns*). As shown in Table 6, the standardized beta coefficient shows that neither of the controls nor any of the organizational discontinuities had a significant relationship with job satisfaction, thus failing to provide support for H1-H4.

To test H5 and H6, we added the organizational continuities of team identification and shared vision respectively into our models in Model 3 and Model 4. H5 predicted that team identification would be positively related to job satisfaction. Comparing to Model 2, results in Model 3 indicate that adding team identification added a considerable amount of explained variance ($\Delta R^2 = 0.20$, $p < .01$), making the overall regression equation significant, $F(7, 149) = 7.78$, $p < .01$. Thus, H5 was supported. H6 predicted that shared vision would be positively related to job satisfaction. This hypothesis was also supported when comparing Model 5 to Model 3, $F(7, 149) = 31.12$, $p < .01$, $R^2_{\text{Adjusted}} = 0.37$, $\Delta R^2 = 0.32$, $p < .01$.

H7 predicted that shared vision would moderate the relationship between team identification and job satisfaction. Contrasting Model 5 with Model 6 showed a significant increase in variance explained by adding an interaction term between team identification and shared vision, $\Delta R^2 = 0.02$, $p < .05$. Thus, H7 was supported. When controlling for all other variables, the interaction between team identification and shared vision still had a significant effect on job satisfaction, $B = -0.88$, $t(151) = -2.02$, $p < .05$. We further probed this moderation effect using the PROCESS model in SPSS. Results showed a significant moderation effect by shared vision ($F = 4.10$, $p < .05$) when team identification was low or medium. As recommended by Aiken and West (1991), we then plotted the conditional effects of this moderation using three values of shared vision: one standard deviation above the mean for high shared vision, mean for moderate shared vision, and one standard deviation below the mean for low shared vision. As Fig. 2 with the three fitted lines shows, high shared vision helps buffer the negative effects of low team identification on job satisfaction.

5. Discussion

At a time when exploring connectivity among workers is especially critical, this study set out to explore the role of organizational discontinuities and continuities in explaining the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals working in a software services offshoring MNE. Our findings suggest that organizational discontinuities arising from virtual work boundaries have no bearing on the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals, but that their job satisfaction is enhanced by team-level continuities they develop through a sense of identification and shared vision, that make them feel more connected to their global teams.

5.1. Theoretical implications

The findings have implications for Organizational Discontinuity Theory in MNEs. Our findings suggest that discontinuities may not always be problematic, and that they may have become so normalized in global work arrangements that they do not hinder job satisfaction in and of themselves. Watson-Manheim et al. (2012) acknowledge that boundaries pose both barriers and opportunities for

Table 6
Hierarchical regression analysis predicting job satisfaction of contract workers ($N = 156$).

Variable	Job satisfaction					
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Intercept	3.71	3.32	1.60	1.38	0.79	−0.95
Team Tenure	0.03	0.03	0.02	0.01	0.01	0.01
Location	0.17	0.14	0.08	0.11	0.09	0.08
Face-to-Face Dependence		0.09	0.01	0.03	−0.01	−0.02
Cultural Diversity		0.16	0.09	0.08	0.06	0.06
Dynamic Structure		−0.07	0.01	0.03	0.05	0.03
Geographic Dispersion		−0.06	−0.05	−0.09	−0.07	−0.09
Team Identification (TI)			0.48**		0.26**	0.74*
Shared Vision (SV)				0.59**	0.48**	1.02**
TI × SV						−0.88*
Adjusted R^2	0.02	0.03	0.23	0.36	0.41	0.42
ΔR^2	0.03	0.04	0.20	0.32	0.05	0.02
ΔF	2.32	1.57	40.55**	78.25**	13.35**	4.10*

Note. Table values are standardized regression coefficients.
* $p < .05$.
** $p < .01$.

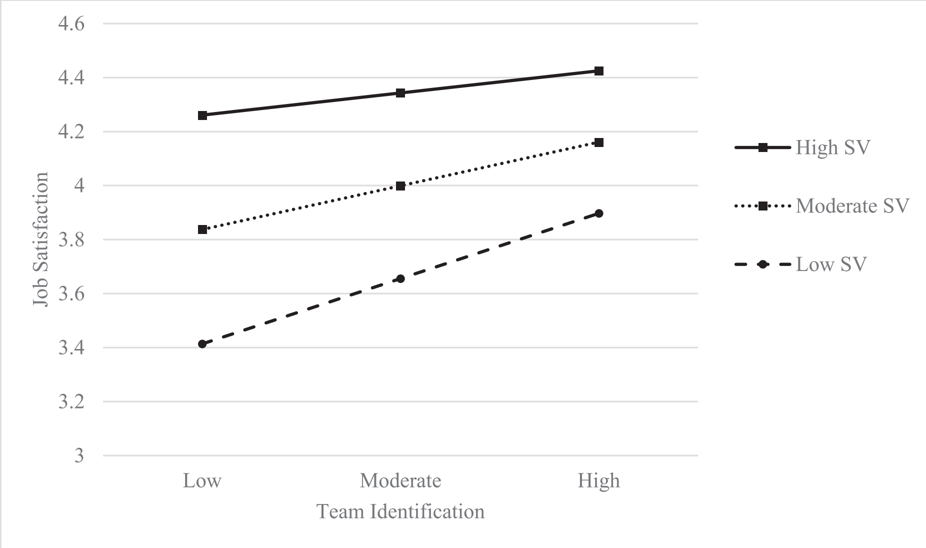

Fig. 2. Scatterplot for the moderating effects of SV on the relationship between TI and Job Satisfaction.

innovation, and specifically that boundaries may have an "evolving social nature" such that they are experienced differently depending on the context. Our findings further imply that continuities that provide team level connectivity may be especially important for MNEs using global outsourcing teams as boundary spanning mechanisms, to help overcome discontinuities associated with the virtual work environment that affect offshoring IT professionals, who negotiate dual organizational allegiances and are often treated as lower status (Boswell et al., 2012; Coyle-Shapiro et al., 2006) compared to permanent employees in MNEs. Team identification and shared vision are likely to help offshoring IT professionals manage the inherent uncertainty and ambiguity they face in their work roles and identity, and lead to increased job satisfaction as they provide them with a sense of localized belonging and meaning in their work. While we did not test for interaction effects between the continuities of team identification and shared vision and the organizational discontinuities, they did have significant positive associations with job satisfaction, such that offshoring IT professionals with stronger team identification and shared vision were more satisfied with their work arrangements. Our findings provide further support for the importance of team-level continuities and context in supporting individual workers' ability to manage distance and other discontinuities in global virtual teams (Lauring et al., 2022).

Given that prior empirical research on ODT has focused on internal virtual organizations (Lauring et al., 2022) and those operating within the same time zone (Asiatiani & Penttinen, 2019), our study helps to extend ODT by empirically testing it in an offshoring MNE context, which involves greater complexity by crossing geographical, temporal, cultural, as well as organizational boundaries. Our findings also provide important insights into IS offshoring MNEs – an important and rapidly growing industry that has been understudied – which are different from traditional MNEs in that they are primarily service organizations rather than product-based firms, they lack a clearly defined home market and national origin, and they are often located in developing economies to take advantage of lower labor costs yet set up subsidiaries in both industrialized and developing countries (Gannon, 2007).

Our findings also have implications for theory on virtual and remote work environments and virtuality. First, they suggest that virtuality features do not have a direct association with job satisfaction. Whereas prior research has found that virtuality is associated with lower job satisfaction (Gallupe et al., 1988; Gurtner et al., 2007) – likely due to the fact that it is more difficult to coordinate work, share knowledge, and establish meaningful relationships with colleagues in different locations, who are "out of sight, out of mind" (Cramton et al., 2007; Grinter et al., 1999) – in the past two decades, distributed work has become ubiquitous and normalized. Our findings suggest that geographical dispersion, lack of face-to-face interaction, cultural diversity, and dynamic structure may not be perceived as disruptive by offshoring IT professionals. Given that workers (especially knowledge workers, such as software industry professionals) have become much more accustomed to working virtually, the non-significant relationship of these features and job satisfaction suggests that working virtually is now less likely to pose challenges, especially in a software offshoring MNE where distributed collaboration has become the norm. Workers may also be overcoming the learning curve associated with new technology use, such that computer-mediated teamwork has become taken for granted. These findings suggest the need to rethink our assumptions about virtuality, especially assumptions that it is associated with performance challenges or other deficiencies due to the reduced socioemotional cues in computer-mediated communication (Raghuram et al., 2019). They also suggest the need to unpack and decouple various dimensions of virtuality and examine their independent effects. While this argument has been made by prior research on virtuality (e.g., Gibson and Gibbs, 2006), the virtual teams research continues to treat virtuality features as conflated, or at least correlated.

In addition, our findings have implications for contemporary remote and virtual work environments in the post-COVID era. Understanding the interplay between discontinuities and continuities may help to explain why the shift to remote or virtual work has had mixed positive and negative effects on team collaboration (Fayard et al., 2021; Szelwach and Matthews, 2021; Waizenegger et al., 2020). Our findings highlight the importance of team-level connection and shared goals in providing remote workers with satisfying work. These critical mechanisms may help to combat the professional and social isolation many remote workers experience (Asatiani and Penttinen, 2019).

5.2. Practical implications

As MNEs and other types of organizations increasingly rely on global virtual collaboration, the ability to manage boundary complexities and coordinate across different boundaries has become increasingly important in order for global organizations to be successful (Schotter et al., 2017). Our findings suggest that understanding factors that influence the job satisfaction of global workers is key in facilitating boundary spanning processes in MNEs. Organizations utilize offshoring IT professionals to enable greater flexibility in their workforce and thus it is important to understand how the complex and sometimes contradictory features of the global work environment affect these workers' job satisfaction. Our findings highlight the ubiquitous nature of virtuality and suggest that such discontinuities may no longer pose barriers, at least to the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals. Rather, they are most satisfied when while working remotely with geographically distributed, culturally and functionally diverse colleagues, they feel a sense of connection with these teammates through identification and shared vision. This has implications for the design of offshoring strategy in modern MNEs, suggesting that offshoring IT professionals benefit from working in team structures that provide them with a sense of belonging and shared vision. Given the latest developments in many organizations in the context of the global pandemic, it is more important than ever to shed light on factors influencing job satisfaction among virtual and remote workers.

5.3. Limitations and future research

Our study is not without limitations. First, the results may be limited in terms of generalizability. Our sample comprises a single functional group (software developers) in a single division of an MNE, working for one specific client. Thus, we are not able to speak to different types of MNE configurations and boundary-spanning relationships (e.g., Meyer et al., 2020; Schotter et al., 2017). Given the lack of cultural and functional diversity within the IT professionals we studied, it is likely that higher levels of diversity indicate closer proximity to client colleagues in their teams. Given the small numbers of contractors located at the client site (only about 8 % of our sample), we were unable to systematically analyze whether this was the case and whether being located at the client site made a difference in their job satisfaction. It is possible that this population (offshoring IT professionals) may be more accustomed to working virtually than other types of workers, given that their job role requires them to work in geographically dispersed, culturally diverse, and structurally dynamic work environments due to their involvement in global outsourcing arrangements. With a larger sized sample of intact teams, future research should examine the influence of team-level variables and develop multi-level models to consider cross-level interactions at both individual and team levels. In addition, it is important to note that our cross-sectional survey provides only a snapshot in time and does not allow us to speak to causality or changes in job satisfaction over time. The findings could be fruitfully extended through future qualitative research of offshoring IT professionals' processes of identity negotiation to explore how they are connected through team building processes.

Another limitation is that our data were collected prior to Covid-19 and the Russian invasion of Ukraine. Both of these events have dramatically altered the working landscape of outsourcing arrangements in Eastern Europe and the broader world. Many companies with locations in the Ukraine have assisted in relocating their employees to safer areas. Additionally, companies have withdrawn support or business with Russian- and Belarussian-based companies. For this participant pool, it is likely that there is some division between Ukrainian workers and workers from other cultures, particularly Russians and Belarussians, that may not have been as salient prior to Russia's invasion. When viewed through the lens of continuity, some Eastern European workers were able to keep their positions thereby maintaining their professional identities. However, due to the need to relocate for safety, they may experience discontinuities in the forms of time zone changes and personal identity changes stemming from their status as refugees. Future research should capture the effects of these external disruptions more explicitly and the ways in which they lead to discontinuities and continuities in MNEs.

6. Conclusion

While our findings have important boundary conditions, they nevertheless contribute important insights to our understanding of how organizational discontinuities and continuities impact the job satisfaction of offshoring IT professionals in offshoring MNEs, an important population that has been understudied. They are also likely to reflect broader trends among software professionals as well as knowledge workers and increasingly, the more general population, for whom virtual and remote teamwork has already become the norm. Our findings thus provide further understanding of factors at the team level that help to increase global connectivity in organizational contexts that face disruptions due to features of the modern global work environment. Given the widespread nature of virtual work in the post-COVID era, these findings are likely to have relevance beyond the global outsourcing context to remote work more broadly.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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